

“I, John Brown, am now quite certain that the **crimes of this guilty land** will never be **purged** away, but **with blood.**”

A NOTE FROM BROWN TO HIS JAILER BEFORE HIS EXECUTION,
DECEMBER 2, 1859

Reactions to the execution

Public sentiment was polarized between those who celebrated Brown's execution and those who publicly mourned him. Southerners resented Northern expressions of support for Brown. Especially galling was that national figures, such as Ralph Waldo Emerson, compared him to Christ and his gallows to the cross. A Richmond editor remarked that the raid and public responses to it “advanced the cause of disunion more than any event ... since the formation of the government.”